EL1213 · English Language Skills II

Mid-Semester Reference · Academic writing / report grammar

Name: ..... Student ID: .....

A1 · ACADEMIC REGISTER — QUESTION 1 (20 MARKS)

For each item: underline only the offending expression **(1)**; name the correct category **(1)**. If suitable, write **Formal**.

Category / trigger	Academic remedy
Slang / colloquial dumb, awesome, ditch, loaded	neutral, precise vocabulary
Phrasal verb found out, put off, cover up, went up	determined, postponed, concealed, increased
Contraction isn't, aren't, didn't, can't	is not, are not, did not, cannot
Personal reference I, we, our, my, you	impersonal subject / passive
Direct question rhetorical questions	declarative statement / study aim
Absolute claim all, only, never, best, definitely, proves	hedging + evidence; limit claim
Vague quantifier loads, plenty, bunch, a lot	exact count or neutral amount
Biased / insensitive unjustified group labels	respectful, context-precise wording
Figurative idiom slangy fixed expressions	direct, literal academic verb

Answer label: Informal — [category] — "[underlined expression]".

Hedges: may · might · could · appears to · suggests · tends to · possibly · one factor.

Formal signals: precise figures, neutral reporting verbs, cautious claims, appropriate citations, complete verb forms.

A2 · CITATIONS / ACADEMIC STYLE

Paraphrase	Author (year) / (Author, year)
Direct quotation	Quotation marks + author + year + page
Summary	Main ideas in own words + citation

Remember: possessive *'s* is not a contraction; quotation punctuation/source spelling is separate from informal wording. Preserve source names; do not invent page numbers. Match citations to reference list.

B1 · REPORT SKELETON + TENSES — QUESTION 2 (40)

Section	Marks	Structure / tense
Title	1	short noun phrase; ideally ≤10 words
Objective	1	**To + base measurable verb**
Introduction	3	facts/laws: present; actions done: past passive
Apparatus	3	complete list, a/an, quantities as supplied
Procedure	**17**	past passive + sequence + relevant steps
Observation	2	actual result; past
Discussion	**10**	possible past errors + causes/effects
Conclusion	3	recommendations: should be + V3

Measurable verbs: determine · measure · calculate · compare · investigate · test · examine.

Articles: a + consonant sound; an + vowel sound; plural/uncountable nouns do not take singular a/an.

Introduction: singular general fact → **is/does/V-s**; plural general fact → **are/do/V**; completed experiment → **was/were + V3**.

B2 · MASTER PAST-PASSIVE CONVERSION

Imperative procedure note → impersonal record

OBJECT → was / were → V3 → details

Object + was/were + past participle + technical details.

Six decisions: ① find object ② put it first ③ choose was/were ④ add V3 ⑤ retain equipment, method, dimensions and conditions ⑥ join actions with sequence markers.

Agreement	Selection
One item / uncountable noun	**was + V3**
Plural objects / A and B	**were + V3**
Negative past passive	**was/were not + V3**
Modal past possibility	**may have been + V3**
Future improvement	**should be + V3**

Quick nouns: resistor, instrument, circuit, current, voltage → **was**; wires, readings, values, instruments, voltage and current → **were**.

> **Do not put a past action in present simple** simply because the Introduction also contains scientific facts. Decide whether it is a universal fact or an experiment already completed.

VERB BANK · V1 → V2 → V3

Base (V1)	Past (V2)	Participle (V3)
take / make / find	took / made / found	**taken / made / found**
write / draw / build	wrote / drew / built	**written / drawn / built**
read / cut / put / set	read / cut / put / set	**read / cut / put / set**
choose / break / give	chose / broke / gave	**chosen / broken / given**
hold / begin / see	held / began / saw	**held / begun / seen**
measure / record / test	measured / recorded / tested	**measured / recorded / tested**
connect / adjust / check	connected / adjusted / checked	**connected / adjusted / checked**
switch / calculate / compare	switched / calculated / compared	**switched / calculated / compared**
construct / observe / use	constructed / observed / used	**constructed / observed / used**

V3 = past participle, not automatically V2 for irregular verbs. A report describes the action done to an object, not the researcher doing it.

GRAMMAR CHOICE · QUICK DECISION MAP

Law / definition	present simple / present passive
Completed method	was/were + V3
Observed outcome	It was observed that + past fact
Possible past error	may/might/could have (+ been) + V3
Improvement	should/could + be + V3

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B3 · PROCEDURE (17 MARKS) — STEP CHECKLIST

12 marks: actions + 3: sequence markers + 2: omit irrelevant instructions.

Place	Sequence words
Opening	Firstly · Initially · First
Middle	Next · Then · After that · Subsequently · Afterwards · Thereafter
Dependent	After + V-ing · Once + clause · Following this
Ending	Finally · Lastly

Each action: **object + was/were + V3**; combine adjacent actions into a coherent paragraph.

Preserve: step order; electrical/mathematical relationships; measurements; equipment; locations; materials; precautions; sequence; calculations; recordings.

Omit only filler: examiner directions, generic housekeeping, conversational remarks and redundant "remember/ensure" wording. **Keep safety-critical actions** by converting them to passive.

> **Critical model-paper distinction:** generic bench-arrangement directions may be omitted; switching the power supply off before connecting is a genuine safety action and must remain.

Technical prepositions: in series with; in parallel across; using; by measuring; between; to/from; before/after.

Final scan: no imperative verbs; no I/we/you; no missing action; no invented values; correct was/were and V3.

B4 · OBSERVATION & RESULTS (2 MARKS)

It was observed/noticed that + [actual past result].

Describe only the **observed** outcome. Use past tense; retain negative or inconsistent findings. Distinguish **actual** from **expected**. Do not explain a possible error here: that belongs in Discussion.

Results: recorded values / observations → past tense. General explanation of theory in discussion → present tense.

B5 · DISCUSSION: PAST ERROR LANGUAGE

Possible past event or condition:

Subject + may / might / could + have + V3.

Possible action to an object (passive):

Object + may / might / could + have been + V3.

Error type	Typical sources
Observational	viewing angle, parallax, timing
Instrumental	calibration, faulty meter, loose connection
Environmental	temperature, pressure, humidity, supply variation
Personal	wrong reading, arithmetic, setup, handling

Uncertainty: possible errors ≠ verified facts. *May not have* can express uncertain omission; *could not have* can imply impossibility, so choose carefully.

B6 · DISCUSSION PARAGRAPH (10 MARKS)

Mark allocation	Required output
1	topic sentence: actual ≠ expected
2	transitional devices
6	3 possible-error sentences, appropriate verb forms
1	cautious concluding sentence

Topic → possible cause 1 → effect → cause 2 → effect → cause 3 → effect → summary.

Signal	Grammar / use
because / since / as	+ full cause clause
because of / due to / owing to	+ cause noun phrase
therefore / thus / consequently	+ resulting clause (link punctuation)
result in / lead to / cause	+ resulting noun phrase
resulting in	+ consequence noun phrase
Firstly / furthermore / finally	order separate causes

Neutral starters (patterns only):

[Discrepancy] may be attributed to [possible causes].

[Error] might have [V3], resulting in [effect].

[Object] could have been [V3] incorrectly.

In summary, [possible errors] may explain [difference].

> Use exactly the possible causes supplied by the examiner. Do not turn "might have" into "definitely did"; do not invent new failure mechanisms.

B7 · CONCLUSION / IMPROVEMENTS (3 MARKS)

Object + should / could + be + V3 + improvement detail.

Purpose: prevent the identified errors in a future experiment. One recommendation for each supplied fault; retain the proposed corrective action.

Useful V3: checked · secured · inspected · calibrated · maintained · repeated · measured · recorded · adjusted.

Not suitable: commands; "we should…"; claims that the recommendation was already implemented; new unsupported explanations.

Do not confuse: **might have been + V3** = uncertain *past* error; **should be + V3** = *future* recommendation.

FINAL 20-SECOND EXAM CHECK

☐ all headings and materials ☐ all essential steps ☐ technical order/relations ☐ was/were + V3 ☐ markers ☐ no filler ☐ actual observation ☐ 3 causes + 3 effects ☐ cautious modals ☐ matching recommendations ☐ no I/we/you ☐ no invented data.